

ETCH

Carve your story. It won't wash away.

Feature Specification - The Digital Sanctuary
A journaling app for Gen Z and Millennials

Version 1.0 - June 2026
github.com/yibi/etch

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1. The Threshold

The c

WHAT IT IS

When you open Etch, there is no dashboard. No 'Welcome back.' No streak counter. No notification badges. The screen fades in slowly - like theater lights going down.

You see a blank screen with a subtle, pulsating gradient (The Aura). To enter your journal, you hold your thumb anywhere on the screen for 1.5 seconds. During the hold, you feel a slow haptic heartbeat. The gradient responds to your touch, contracting toward your thumb like breathing in.

When you release, the screen dissolves into your journal. You're in.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z is over-stimulated the moment they unlock their phone. Notifications, badges, red dots, algorithmic feeds - all demanding attention. The Threshold is a deliberate decompression zone. It creates a physical, tactile ritual that signals to your brain: you are safe now. The algorithm can't see you. This is a different space.

The 1.5-second hold is long enough to feel intentional but short enough to never feel tedious. It becomes muscle memory after day three. It's the digital equivalent of taking off your shoes at the door.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI ZStack with LinearGradient animation. Hold detected via DragGesture minimumDuration. Haptic feedback via UIImpactFeedbackGenerator (soft, repeated at 0.5s intervals). Transition to journal view via `.transition(.opacity.combined(with: .scale))`. No camera access, no sensor access, no network calls. Pure local UI.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a loading screen. NOT a login wall. NOT a splash animation. It is a deliberate emotional transition zone. If it feels like a loading screen, it failed.

2. The Canvas

WHAT IT IS

The journal entry screen is not a title field followed by a body text editor. It is a free-form canvas. You tap anywhere on the screen to drop a text cursor and start writing. There are no formatting toolbars, no bold/italic buttons, no header styles.

You can tap in the top-left corner and write a sentence. Tap in the middle and write another. Each text block is independent. You can also:

- Drop a photo anywhere (tap and hold to insert from camera roll)
- Record a voice whisper (tap the whisper icon, speak, tap again to stop)
- Add a vibe label (see Vibe Slider)

The canvas scrolls infinitely. There are no pages, no margins, no structure. It's a wall. You write on it wherever you want.

Photos are not displayed in a grid. They are scattered - placed exactly where you tapped, slightly rotated randomly (1-3 degrees), like physical prints thrown on a table.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z does not write 'Dear Diary' entries. Their journaling is modular: a mood rating, a screenshot of a text, a stream-of-consciousness rant, a Spotify log. Forcing them into a title + body structure fights their natural expression.

The canvas mirrors how they actually think - scattered, non-linear, messy. It removes the pressure of 'writing something good' because there's no structure to fill. You just put things on the wall.

Markdown is supported but invisible. Type `##` and it becomes a header. Type `**bold**` and it bolds. No buttons, no ribbons, no UI chrome. The formatting is there if you want it, invisible if you don't.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI ScrollView with a ZStack of draggable text views (TextEditor with transparent background). Photos rendered as Image views with random rotation transform. Voice whispers recorded via AVAudioRecorder, stored as .m4a files alongside the .md entry file. Canvas state serialized as JSON (text blocks with x/y coordinates, photo positions, audio file references). Saved as .md file with frontmatter containing canvas metadata.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a rich text editor. NOT a word processor. NOT a bullet journal. NOT Obsidian. NOT a blank page with a cursor at the top. It is a wall, not a document.

3. The Vibe Slider

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WHAT IT IS

Before or during writing, you slide a horizontal toggle to set the 'room temperature' of the entry. The options are not emotions - they are atmospheres:

- Chaotic (sharp, red-orange texture, fast haptic)
- Static (gray-blue, still, no haptic)
- Melancholy (deep blue-violet, slow haptic)
- Glowing (warm gold, soft haptic)

The selected vibe changes the background texture of the canvas. It's subtle - a faint gradient wash, not a full color flood. The text remains readable. The vibe is saved with the entry as metadata in the .md frontmatter.

You can change the vibe at any time while writing. It's not a commitment - it's a weather report for your inner state.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z doesn't rate their mood as '3 out of 5 stars' or pick a smiley face. That's reductive and corporate. But they DO think in vibes - 'today feels chaotic,' 'I'm in a melancholy mood.' The Vibe Slider gives them a language that matches how they actually communicate emotion.

The background texture change is the key. It makes the entry FEEL different, not just labeled differently. A 'Chaotic' entry literally looks different from a 'Melancholy' entry when you scroll through your timeline. Your journal becomes a visual weather record, not just a text archive.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI Slider bound to an enum (chaotic/static/melancholy/glowing). Each vibe maps to a LinearGradient with specific colors and opacity. Background applied as a ZStack layer behind the canvas. Haptic feedback via UIImpactFeedbackGenerator with different intensities per vibe. Stored in .md frontmatter as 'vibe: melancholy'.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT mood emojis. NOT a 1-5 rating. NOT a dropdown. NOT a required field. It's a vibe, not a metric.

4. Internal Weather

Paint

WHAT IT IS

Internal Weather is a full-screen interactive mood painting. Instead of selecting a mood from a list, you rub your thumb on the screen. The app interprets your touch:

- Fast, sharp movements = high energy, anxious, manic. Visual: grainy, high-contrast noise. Haptic: sharp taps.
- Slow, gentle movements = low energy, calm, depressed. Visual: misty, blurred, soft. Haptic: slow, deep rumbles.
- Circular movements = processing, ruminating. Visual: swirling gradient. Haptic: rolling.
- No movement (just holding) = numb, empty. Visual: flat, muted. Haptic: single slow pulse.

The result is not a number. It's a texture - a visual artifact of your emotional state at that moment. It's saved as part of the entry.

You can do this before writing, after writing, or instead of writing. Some days you can't put it into words. You just paint.

WHY IT EXISTS

91% of Gen Z report stress symptoms. Many can't articulate what they're feeling - they just know it's 'bad.' Asking them to name their emotion is itself a barrier. Painting it removes the cognitive load.

The haptic dimension is critical. Gen Z is starved for tactile feedback in a flat-glass world. The physical sensation of rubbing your phone and feeling it respond to your emotional state is deeply grounding. It's a nervous system regulation tool disguised as a journaling feature.

This is also what makes Etch feel like a sanctuary, not a tool. You don't 'input data.' You express yourself.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI Canvas view with gesture tracking. Touch velocity, direction, and duration analyzed in real-time. Renders a procedural texture using Metal shaders or Core Image filters (noise density, blur radius, color saturation driven by touch parameters). Haptic feedback via CHHapticEngine (custom patterns, not just impact). The rendered texture is saved as a small PNG thumbnail in the .md frontmatter.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a mood wheel. NOT a questionnaire. NOT a graph input. It's painting, not data entry.

5. The Color Cloud

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WHAT IT IS

At the end of each month, the app generates a Color Cloud - an abstract visualization of your month's emotional landscape. It aggregates all your Vibe Slider settings and Internal Weather textures into a single abstract image.

It's not a graph. It's not a chart. It's not a calendar heatmap. It looks like a watercolor painting or an aurora - swirls of color that represent the texture of your month.

A month that was mostly 'Chaotic' with some 'Glowing' days will look like a storm with patches of gold. A month that was 'Static' throughout will look like a flat, muted fog.

The Color Cloud is displayed at the top of your timeline for that month, saveable to your photo roll as a PNG, and used as input for the End of Month Aura video.

You can look back at your Color Clouds and see your emotional history as art, not data.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z loves 'Spotify Wrapped' style self-reflection, but they don't want their mental health quantified into a chart. A graph says 'you were 43% sad this month.' A Color Cloud says 'your February was deep indigo and static.'

It turns mental health tracking into something beautiful instead of clinical. It makes you want to look at your history. It makes you want to share the aesthetic (without sharing the content).

This is also the foundation of the viral feature (End of Month Aura). The Color Cloud IS the visual asset that drives TikTok sharing.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Core Image or Metal composite renderer. Aggregates vibe frequencies and weather texture thumbnails from the month's entries. Generates a 1080x1080 abstract image using procedural blending (similar to generative art). No external API, no AI service. Pure local rendering. Saved as .png alongside the month's entries.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a bar chart. NOT a mood calendar. NOT a streak tracker. NOT a 'you journaled 23 days this month' stat. It's art, not analytics.

6. The Echo

One

WHAT IT IS

When you open Etch and complete the Threshold hold, sometimes - not always - a single sentence or single photo fades in on the screen for 3 seconds before dissolving into your canvas.

It's pulled from an entry exactly 1 year ago, 6 months ago, or 3 months ago (rotating). Just one line. One image. A whisper.

There is no 'On This Day' feed. No carousel of past entries. No timeline you can scroll. Just one moment, briefly surfaced, then gone.

If you want to read more from that day, you can tap the whisper before it fades. It opens that entry. If you do nothing, it dissolves and you're in your canvas.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z doesn't want 'Nostalgia' (that's Facebook's domain). They want 'Personal Lore' - the realization that they are a person with a history, not just a consumer in a feed.

The emotional purpose is perspective: seeing that the 'world-ending crisis' from six months ago is now just a whisper on a screen. It reminds you that you survived things you thought you wouldn't. It grounds you in continuity.

Showing ONE thing, briefly, is more powerful than showing everything. A feed of past entries becomes a browsing experience. A single whisper becomes an emotional experience.

It's called The Echo (not 'Memories' or 'On This Day') because it's not about remembering - it's about resonance.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftDB or UserDefaults query for entries on the same date in previous years/months. Random selection of one entry. Extract first sentence (or first photo). Display via SwiftUI .transition(.opacity) with 3-second Timer. Tap gesture opens full entry. If no past entry exists on that date, no Echo is shown. No notification, no badge.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT 'On This Day.' NOT a memories feed. NOT a notification. NOT a carousel. It's a whisper, not a slideshow.

7. Anti-Journal Prompts

Shad

WHAT IT IS

Prompts are entirely optional and OFF by default. If enabled in settings, a small prompt appears at the bottom of the canvas when you start a new entry. You can swipe it away.

The prompts are NOT:

- 'What are 3 things you're grateful for?'
- 'Describe your perfect day.'
- 'What made you smile today?'

The prompts ARE:

- 'What is a secret you're keeping from yourself?'
- 'Write a DM to someone that you will never, ever send. Purge it here.'
- 'What's a vibe shift you've noticed in your own head this week?'
- 'Describe today's energy using only textures ('cracked glass,' 'warm velvet').'
- 'What are you pretending not to know?'
- 'Write the thing you're most afraid someone will find out about you.'
- 'If your anxiety had a texture, what would it feel like?'
- 'What would you write if you knew no one would ever read it?'

Prompts rotate and never repeat within a 30-day window. They're stored locally - no server, no API, no AI generation.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z hates 'toxic positivity' prompts. 'What are you grateful for?' feels boomer and reductive. It ignores that you can be grateful for coffee AND depressed about the housing market simultaneously.

But Gen Z DOES want guidance. #ShadowWork has 2 billion views on TikTok. They want prompts that go dark, that go real, that give them permission to be messy and honest. The Anti-Journal prompts are designed to unlock the raw, unfiltered expression that Gen Z craves.

The prompts are also carefully written to feel like they come from a peer, not a therapist or a corporation. They're casual, slightly provocative, and never preachy.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Swift array of 30+ prompt strings, stored in a local .swift file. Random selection with UserDefaults tracking for 30-day deduplication. Display via SwiftUI Text with swipe-to-dismiss gesture. Toggle in Settings (default: OFF). No network call, no AI, no server. Pure local.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT gratitude prompts. NOT AI-generated. NOT daily reminders. NOT mandatory. NOT corporate wellness.

8. The Burn Folder

WHAT IT IS

The Burn Folder is a special section of Etch where entries automatically delete themselves 24 hours after creation. No trace. No archive. No recovery.

When you create an entry, you can choose: 'Journal' (saved forever to your iCloud) or 'Burn' (deleted in 24 hours).

Burn entries are visually distinct - the canvas has a subtle warm edge, like paper about to catch fire. The countdown is shown as a small, fading ember icon (not a timer, not a countdown number).

When the 24 hours pass, the entry is permanently deleted. The .md file is removed from the device. No trash, no Recently Deleted folder, no undo.

You CAN read a Burn entry during its 24-hour life. You CANNOT recover it after.

Note: Burn entries do NOT sync to iCloud. They live only on the device.

WHY IT EXISTS

Some things need to be written, not kept. The rage text to your ex. The panic spiral at 3am. The intrusive thought you need to externalize but never see again.

This is purgative journaling - you write to release, not to remember. The Burn Folder gives Gen Z permission to write the ugly, the messy, the shameful, knowing it will be gone by tomorrow.

This is emotionally powerful because it removes the fear of your own words. In a normal journal, you might self-censor because 'what if someone reads this someday?' In the Burn Folder, there is no 'someday.' It's now or never.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Separate storage path for Burn entries (local only, NOT in iCloud Drive folder). Each Burn entry has a creation timestamp. Background task checks for expired entries on app launch and via background app refresh. File deleted via `FileManager.removeItem`. No iCloud sync. No backup. No recovery. Visual: subtle orange/red gradient edge on canvas. Ember icon with opacity decreasing over 24 hours.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT 'Recently Deleted.' NOT a draft folder. NOT a trash can with recovery. It's a furnace. When it's gone, it's gone.

9. The Redact Tool

Black

WHAT IT IS

While writing on the canvas, you can select any text and tap 'Redact.' The selected text is immediately replaced with a solid black bar - like a redacted government document.

The original text is permanently destroyed. The black bar is not a mask over hidden text - the text is actually deleted and replaced with a placeholder marker in the .md file.

You can redact individual words, sentences, or entire paragraphs. Once redacted, it cannot be un-redacted. There is no 'reveal' button.

WHY IT EXISTS

Sometimes the healing is in writing the thing and then immediately hiding it from your own eyes. You needed to get it out. You didn't need to keep it.

This is different from the Burn Folder. Burn deletes the entire entry after 24 hours. Redact lets you keep the entry but destroy specific parts of it. Maybe you wrote a rant and want to keep the conclusion but destroy the specific accusations. Redact lets you curate your own vulnerability.

For Gen Z, this is emotionally resonant. They understand redaction - it's a meme, it's a cultural touchpoint (redacted CIA documents, blacked-out tweets). It turns self-censorship into an act of power, not fear. YOU choose what to hide. It's not hidden from you by a corporation - you hid it from yourself, on your own terms.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Text selection via SwiftUI text interaction. On 'Redact' tap, selected substring is removed from the text model and replaced with a string of '#' characters (visual black bar). The original text is NOT stored anywhere - it's permanently deleted from the text buffer. The .md file contains only the redacted version. No undo, no history, no diff.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a spoiler/tag. NOT a collapsed section. NOT a 'show more' button. NOT reversible. It's permanent erasure with a visible scar.

10. The Wax Seal

WHAT IT IS

When you finish an entry and tap 'Done' (or swipe down to close), the app doesn't show a spinning loading indicator or a 'Saved!' toast. Instead, a brief animation plays: a wax seal closes across the screen, like sealing a letter.

The seal is green (Etch's accent color) with a subtle 'E' embossed. It presses into view with a haptic 'thud,' holds for 0.5 seconds, then dissolves as the screen transitions back to the timeline.

The entire animation takes 1.2 seconds. It's not slow - it's deliberate.

WHY IT EXISTS

Privacy is invisible in most apps. 'End-to-end encrypted' is a text label. 'No servers' is a bullet point. Gen Z has been burned by apps that CLAIM privacy but don't deliver. They don't trust text claims.

The Wax Seal makes privacy FELT. When you see a physical seal close on your entry, you feel that it's locked. It's sealed. It's yours. It's not going to a server. It's not being analyzed. It's sealed shut.

This is experiential privacy - you don't read that your data is safe, you FEEL that your data is safe. The haptic thud of the seal landing is the sound of privacy.

The animation also serves as a closing ritual. The Threshold is the opening ritual (entering the sanctuary). The Wax Seal is the closing ritual (leaving the sanctuary). Together they create a complete emotional arc: enter -> write -> seal -> leave.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI overlay animation. Wax seal rendered as a scaled Image or custom Shape that animates from 0 to full size with spring response (damping: 0.7, stiffness: 80). Haptic via UIImpactFeedbackGenerator (heavy, single impact). Transition out via .transition(.opacity). Total duration: 1.2s. No network call - the save is already complete (local file write) before the animation starts.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a loading spinner. NOT a 'Saved!' toast. NOT a progress bar. It's a ritual, not a status indicator.

11. End of Month Aura

The T

WHAT IT IS

On the last day of each month (or the first day of the new month), Etch generates a 5-second video called your 'End of Month Aura.'

The video is composed of:

- Your Color Cloud for the month (abstract mood visualization)
- Your Internal Weather textures (aggregated)
- A subtle ambient generative soundscape (procedural, not music)
- Film grain and vignette overlay
- Your month name in minimal typography ('June 2026')

The video is 5 seconds long, 1080x1920 (TikTok/Reels format), and contains ZERO text from your entries. It reveals nothing about what you wrote. It only shows the aesthetic of your mental state - your 'aura.'

You can preview it in the app, save it to your photo roll, and share it directly to TikTok, Instagram Reels, or Snapchat.

The video is watermarked with a small, subtle 'Etch' logo in the bottom corner.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z shares their identity, not their content. They post 'aesthetic journaling' videos on TikTok (pen sounds, page flips) - they signal 'I am someone who journals' without revealing what they wrote. The End of Month Aura is the perfect sharing artifact: it's beautiful, it's personal, it's shareable, and it reveals NOTHING private.

This is the viral engine. When someone posts their 'June Aura' on TikTok, their followers see an abstract, gorgeous video and think 'what app is that?' The watermark drives discovery. The aesthetic drives desire.

It's the Spotify Wrapped model: you share the wrapper, not the content. But unlike Spotify, the content is your deepest thoughts - so the wrapper is ALL you'd ever want to share.

The video is generated locally on-device. No server, no rendering farm, no API.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

AVAssetWriter + AVAssetWriterInput for video export. Color Cloud PNG composited with weather textures via Core Image. Generative audio via AVAudioEngine with AVAudioSourceNode (procedural noise + ambient drone). Film grain via CIFilter (noise) overlaid. 1080x1920, 30fps, 5 seconds. Watermark as small SwiftUI Text overlay rendered into the composition. Share sheet via UIActivityViewController.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a slideshow of your entries. NOT a 'year in review' with stats. NOT a graph or chart. It's a vibe, not a report.

12. The Local Pulse

WHAT IT IS

A tiny, constant green dot in the top-right corner of every screen in Etch. It pulses softly - a slow, breathing glow that never stops.

If you tap it, a small tooltip appears: 'Local Only. Your entries never leave your device. No servers. No tracking. No analytics.'

The pulse is subtle enough to ignore but always there in your peripheral vision. It's not a notification. It's not a badge. It's a heartbeat - the heartbeat of your privacy.

When you save an entry to iCloud, the pulse briefly turns blue for 2 seconds (indicating iCloud sync), then returns to green.

WHY IT EXISTS

Privacy is not a feature you check once in Settings. It's a state you should FEEL constantly. Gen Z has been trained by a decade of data breaches and surveillance capitalism to assume every app is watching them. A single 'Privacy' toggle in settings is not enough to overcome that distrust.

The Local Pulse is a constant, ambient reassurance. It's the feeling of knowing your front door is locked without having to check. It's there in your peripheral vision, always breathing, always green, always saying 'you're safe here.'

The color change to blue during iCloud sync is important - it visually confirms that your data is going to YOUR iCloud, not a company server. Green = local only. Blue = syncing to your iCloud. Never red, never yellow, never alarming.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI Circle with a pulsing animation (scale 1.0 to 1.15, opacity 0.6 to 1.0, duration 2s, repeatForever). Green (#00C853) by default, blue (#007AFF) during iCloud sync. Tap gesture shows a SwiftUI Popover with privacy text. Positioned as a small 6px circle in the top-right via ZStack overlay. No network monitoring, no sensor access.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a status bar. NOT a notification. NOT a settings toggle. NOT a privacy policy link. It's a heartbeat, not a label.

Feature Summary

Feature	Build Effort	Emotional Value
1. The Threshold	Low	Entry ritual - signals safety
2. The Canvas	High	Core writing experience
3. The Vibe Slider	Low	Emotional language for entries
4. Internal Weather	High	Mood without words
5. The Color Cloud	Medium	Monthly mood as art
6. The Echo	Low	Perspective, not nostalgia
7. Anti-Journal Prompts	Low	Permission to be messy
8. The Burn Folder	Medium	Write to release, not remember
9. The Redact Tool	Low	Power over your own words
10. The Wax Seal	Low	Privacy you can feel
11. End of Month Aura	High	TikTok viral engine
12. The Local Pulse	Low	Constant privacy reassurance

Recommended Build Order (MVP -> Phase 2)

- MVP (Weeks 1-4): Threshold + Canvas + Vibe Slider + Wax Seal + Local Pulse
- Phase 2 (Weeks 5-8): Internal Weather + Color Cloud + The Echo + Anti-Journal Prompts
- Phase 3 (Weeks 9-12): Burn Folder + Redact Tool + End of Month Aura